

the side-effect of stabilizing the soil it is growing in. When land such as this is plowed and the grass removed, the soil rapidly deteriorates and is blown away as dust, leaving only bare earth in its place.

Tropical grasslands

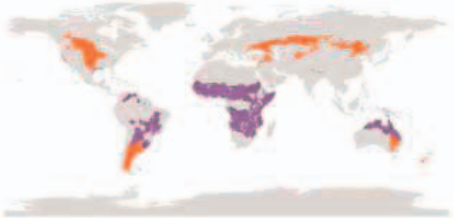
Scattered trees and scrub are a feature of tropical savannas, making them more diverse than their temperate counterparts. However, they cannot encroach far because, unlike grass, trees and scrub cannot survive the frequent fires that occur during the dry season. Although these fires appear destructive, the ash created provides soil nutrients that fuel the growth of fresh grass during the wet season that follows.

While some tropical grasses, such as bamboo and elephant grass, grow very tall, most savanna grassland provides little cover, making it difficult for both predators and prey to hide. Predators rely on stealth, speed, and sometimes cooperation to catch their food, whereas prey animals rely on spotting hunters before they

GRASSLAND DISTRIBUTION

The largest temperate grasslands are the prairies of North America and the Asian steppes, which stretch from the far east of Europe to northern China. Tropical grasslands include those of sub-Saharan Africa and Brazil.

Temperate grasslands Tropical grasslands



get too close and running away. They do this by living in groups, which offers safety in numbers, and by relying on their senses.

Prey animals have eyes on the sides of their heads for good all around vision, large swiveling ears, and an excellent sense of smell—hares are a good example.



SCRUB

In areas with long dry summers such as California and the Mediterranean, there is a transition zone between woods and grassland that is dominated by low, woody shrub vegetation. Also called heathland and chaparral, scrub offers more cover for animals.



TROPICAL GRASSLAND

These are usually warm year-round, with a long dry season followed by a short wet season that sees a spurt of plant growth. African savanna elephants help to maintain their habitat by eating woody shrubs and knocking down trees to feed on their leaves.



WETLANDS

Areas of land that are routinely inundated by fresh or salt water are often dominated by grasses, reeds, and sedges, while water hyacinths form free-floating mats of vegetation. Wetlands support many species, particularly birds.

